

THE
COMPLETE
STORY
OF
FORMULA 1

FULL THROTTLE



ZED

Author's Note

This is a book about speed. But it is also a book about human beings — their courage and their cruelty, their genius and their grief. Formula 1 is the most technically complex sport in the world, but at its beating heart are stories that anyone can feel: rivalry, redemption, tragedy, triumph.

I have tried to write for the uninitiated — for the person who has never watched a Grand Prix but is curious about why millions do. I have also tried to write for the devoted fan who wants the story told with fresh eyes. Every fact in these pages has been researched and verified.

The sport has claimed lives and shattered records. It has produced villains and saints, often in the same driver. It has survived fires, crashes, scandals, and the deaths of legends. And it is still here.

— Zed, 2026

C H A P T E R 0 1

01 The World Starts Its Engine

Silverstone · 13 May 1950

The date is 13 May 1950. The place is Silverstone, a former Royal Air Force airfield in the English countryside, its runways repurposed as the world's most improbable racetrack. Haystacks line the corners. The pits are wooden shacks. And yet seventy thousand people have come — jostling against rope barriers, perched on fences, craning their necks for a first glimpse of something the world has never seen before: the inaugural Formula One World Championship.

King George VI and Queen Elizabeth are in attendance. The cars lined up on the grid are unlike anything on the public road: low-slung, open-wheeled, snarling with supercharged purpose. The dominant force is Alfa Romeo, fielding three of the fastest drivers in the world — Giuseppe 'Nino' Farina, Juan Manuel Fangio, and Luigi Fagioli — a trio the paddock calls 'the Three Fs.'

When the flag drops, Farina surges into the lead. He drives with a distinctive, arms-outstretched style, his back straight, his expression glacial behind his goggles. He is 43 years old, a late bloomer who has spent decades on the circuit. He does not waste his moment. He crosses the line first — the winner of the very first Formula One World Championship race in history.

F A S T F A C T S

· 1 9 5 0 E R A

First ever F1 race

13 May 1950
Silverstone,
England

First champion

Nino Farina (Italy)
Alfa Romeo

Fangio's record

5 titles in 6 seasons
4 different teams

Safety equipment

No seatbelts, No
fire suits, No
barriers

By the end of the season, Farina is champion — but only barely. Fangio, the Argentine maestro, finishes a single point behind, robbed by mechanical failure in the final race. It is an early preview of a theme Formula 1 will return to again and again: greatness decided by the thinnest of margins.

Over the next seven years, Fangio's brilliance becomes the sport's founding mythology. He wins five world championships in six seasons, driving for four different teams. He is strategic, calculating, brilliant under pressure — the complete racing driver before anyone had defined what that meant.

At the 1957 German Grand Prix, he overcomes a pitstop disaster and hunts down the leading Ferraris with a series of lap records, winning by a margin that leaves the crowd breathless. Many still call it the greatest single race performance in history.

The cars of this era are brutally dangerous. There are no seatbelts. The fuel tanks sit adjacent to the driver. Circuits like the original Nurburgring stretch for nearly 23 kilometres through the Eifel mountains, their 170-plus corners shielded only by trees and prayer. Fatalities are common, accepted with a tragic shrug as the cost of the spectacle.

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"He was not just a champion. He was THE champion. The standard by which all others are measured." — Stirling Moss on Juan Manuel Fangio

Fangio retires in 1958. No one expects anyone to match his record of five titles. No one suspects they are standing at the quiet beginning of a hurricane.



▲ Formula 1 race start — the most electrifying 90 seconds in motorsport. Twenty cars, one track, one chance.

C H A P T E R 0 2

02 Fire on the Mountain

Lauda vs Hunt · The 1976 Championship

By the mid-1970s, Formula 1 has grown into a global spectacle — faster, richer, and more dangerous than ever. The cars now produce staggering downforce, gripping corners at speeds that seem to defy physics. And at the centre of it all is a duel so dramatic that it will one day become a Hollywood film.

Niki Lauda is Austrian, precise, and cerebral. He dissects a car like an engineer, communicates feedback with clinical accuracy, and is contemptuous of risk taken for its own sake. James Hunt is his opposite: English, reckless, charismatic, possessed of a charm that makes him as compelling off the track as on it. They are teammates-turned-rivals, and their 1976 championship battle will become the most compelling in the sport's history.

Lauda begins the year dominant in his Ferrari. By midsummer, he leads the championship with a comfortable buffer. Then comes the 1st of August — the German Grand Prix at the Nurburgring.

THE NURBURGRING · 'THE GREEN HELL'

Circuit length
22.8 kilometres

Corners
170+

Average lap
7+ minutes

Safety
No fire marshals at corners
No rescue vehicles
Lauda lobbied for a boycott

Lauda has spent the days before the race lobbying his fellow drivers to boycott the circuit. The 23-kilometre course winds through forests and hills with no proper safety infrastructure — no adequate fire marshals, no rescue vehicles at the most vulnerable points. The drivers vote. The boycott fails. They race.

On lap two, Lauda's Ferrari leaves the road at a fast kink, bounces into an earth bank, and erupts in a fireball. The car is trapped. The fuel is burning. Lauda is inside — conscious and screaming. Four drivers stop. They pull him from the wreckage. The fire has been inside his helmet. His face

is devastated — burns to his scalp, eyelids, and ears. His lungs are seared from inhaling superheated gases. A priest is summoned to administer the last rites.

Niki Lauda is expected to die.



▲ Rescuers reach Lauda's burning Ferrari at the Nurburgring, 1 August 1976. Four fellow drivers stopped and risked their own lives to pull him from the inferno.

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"My injuries were not beautiful. But I was not racing for beauty."
— **Niki Lauda**

He does not die. Six weeks later — forty-two days after the accident — Lauda is at the Italian Grand Prix in Monza. His face is still raw and weeping under his bandaged helmet. He qualifies fifth. He finishes fourth. He stands before the press corps afterwards and simply says: 'I am back.'

The championship comes down to the final race in Japan, at Fuji, in driving rain. Hunt needs a win. Lauda — now trailing by three points — needs merely to finish in the top three. But the conditions are biblical: standing water, zero visibility, spray turning the circuit into a grey fog.

After two laps, Lauda pulls into the pits. He climbs out of his car. He will not risk his life — not again, not for this. Hunt, driving like a man possessed, charges through the field. He finishes third. It is enough. He is world champion by a single point.



▲ *The scale of the wreckage. The fire burned for over a minute. That Lauda survived was a miracle. That he raced six weeks later was considered insanity.*

Lauda will come back and win again — two more titles, on his own terms. But the image that endures from 1976 is not a trophy. It is a man in a racing helmet with half a face, willing himself back to life because the only thing he fears more than dying is not being who he is.



03 The Turbo Wars

CHAPTER 03

Technology Redraws the Map · 1977–1988

For most of Formula 1's first three decades, the cars were works of inspired mechanical artistry: naturally aspirated engines, sleek bodies, genius wrought in steel and aluminium. Then, in 1977, a French manufacturer called Renault arrived at the British Grand Prix with something different. Something nuclear.

The turbocharger — a device that forces extra air into an engine's combustion chamber using exhaust gases — was not new technology. But applied to a Formula 1 engine, it was transformative. Renault's 1.5-litre V6 turbo produced more power than the traditional 3-litre naturally aspirated cars competing against it. Initially unreliable, it was also blindingly fast when it worked. The paddock treated it as an amusing curiosity. They were wrong.

Simultaneously, Lotus designer Colin Chapman was reshaping aerodynamics. His Lotus 78, then the 79, pioneered 'ground effect' — whereby the car's underbody was sculpted to create a low-pressure zone beneath it, sucking the car to the tarmac. In 1978, Lotus and Mario Andretti dominated the championship. The FIA banned ground effect in 1983, and a pure turbo arms race was unleashed.

TURBO ERA · KEY NUMBERS

1977

Renault debuts F1 turbo engine at British Grand Prix

1983

Ground effect banned — pure turbo power takes over

1986

Qualifying turbos reach ~1,500 horsepower from a 1.5-litre engine

1988

McLaren wins 15 of 16 races — most dominant season ever recorded

By 1986, qualifying turbos were producing an estimated 1,500 horsepower — from engines smaller than a briefcase. The cars were terrifyingly fast and brutally hard to drive. Nelson Piquet, three-time champion, called them 'the most difficult machines I ever put my hands on.'

By 1988, the turbo era was being wound down. The last year of turbo engines was also its most extraordinary: McLaren's MP4/4, with Honda power and Ayrton Senna and Alain Prost at the wheel, won fifteen of the sixteen races on the calendar. It was the most dominant single season any team has ever produced.

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"The turbo cars were the most difficult machines I ever put my hands on. Magnificent. Terrifying." — Nelson Piquet

And the two men sharing the McLaren garage had already begun to despise each other.



C H A P T E R 0 4

04 Legends at War

Senna vs Prost · The Greatest Rivalry in Motorsport

There have been rivalries in Formula 1. And then there is Senna versus Prost. It is the sport's defining duel — a collision of two entirely different philosophies about what it means to be a racing driver, compressed into three years of barely controlled fury.

Alain Prost is 'The Professor.' Methodical, intelligent, politically astute, he manages a race the way a chess grandmaster manages a game — never using more effort than is required, always playing the long game. By 1988, he already has three world championships. He is, by any measure, the best driver in the world.

Then Ayrton Senna arrives at McLaren.

The Brazilian is something different. He drives with a ferocity that borders on the supernatural, extracting performance from a car that no telemetry can fully explain. He speaks about his fastest laps in almost mystical terms — about feeling disconnected from his own body, about moving beyond the physical into something pure. He is also, on and off the track, intensely difficult: obsessive, and possessed of a win-at-all-costs philosophy that made him both breathtaking and occasionally dangerous to be near.

SENNA VS PROST · THE THREE-YEAR WAR

1988

McLaren wins 15/16 Senna
champion Margin: 3 points

1989

Suzuka collision Senna
disqualified Prost champion
+16 pts

1990

Senna rams Prost at Turn 1,
Suzuka Senna champion

In 1988, they share a garage and finish first and second in the championship, Senna taking the title by three points. The tensions are already volcanic. At the San Marino Grand Prix, the two had agreed not to race each other into the first corner after a restart. Senna ignored the agreement. Prost never forgave him.

In 1989, at Suzuka with the championship on the line, Senna dives to the inside of Prost in the chicane. They collide. Both cars stall. Prost climbs out. Senna gets a push start from marshals — illegal — and wins the race. Then he is disqualified. Prost is champion by sixteen points.

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"I will never make the first move in a collision with Senna. He knows that, and he takes advantage of it." — Alain Prost, 1989

Prost moves to Ferrari for 1990. At Suzuka, on the first lap, approaching the first corner at racing speed, Senna drives his McLaren straight into the back of Prost's Ferrari. Both cars are out. Senna is champion. Years later, Senna would admit he had done it deliberately — cold, calculated retaliation.

The world reacted with shock, and also with something uncomfortable: understanding. Because that was Senna. He was not simply a racing driver. He was a force of nature wearing a yellow helmet, and when nature collides with something in its path, it does not apologise.

Prost retires in 1993, a four-time champion. Senna is faster than ever as 1994 begins. At Imola, in early May, everything changes.



05 CHAPTER 05 The Black Weekend

Imola · 1st May 1994

Formula 1 had been, for the previous decade, growing safer. The turbo cars were gone. The circuits were better managed. There had not been a death at a Grand Prix since 1982. Somewhere in the sport's collective consciousness, the uncomfortable possibility had begun to form: perhaps the worst was behind them.

The 1994 San Marino Grand Prix at Imola would destroy that illusion.

The weekend begins badly. On Friday, Rubens Barrichello — only 21 — crashes heavily at the Variante Bassa and is taken to hospital. On Saturday, the mood becomes dread. Roland Ratzenberger, an Austrian rookie in only his second Grand Prix, is killed in qualifying when his front wing fails at high speed. His car slams into a concrete barrier. He dies instantly — the first driver killed at a Formula One event in twelve years.

IMOLA 1994 · A WEEKEND IN TRAGEDY

Fri 29 Apr

Barrichello crashes at Variante Bassa — hospitalised, survives

Sat 30 Apr

Ratzenberger killed in qualifying — first F1 fatality in 12 years

Sun 1 May Lap 7

Senna crashes at Tamburello — 311 km/h into concrete barrier

18:40 local

Ayrton Senna declared dead — three-time world champion, age 34

Senna, three times world champion, breaks protocol and drives to the scene of Ratzenberger's accident. Professor Sid Watkins — the sport's medical chief and Senna's closest friend in the paddock — finds him there. 'Ayrton broke down and cried on my shoulder,' Watkins later wrote. 'He said he did not know if he wanted to race the next day.'

He races. He leads from the start. On lap seven, at the fast left-hand curve called Tamburello, travelling at approximately 311 kilometres per hour, Senna's car leaves the road. It strikes a concrete barrier. The deceleration is catastrophic. Senna's head is struck by suspension debris.

The world watches in silence. Then in grief. Ayrton Senna — three-time world champion, the fastest man who had ever sat in a racing car — is dead at thirty-four years old.

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"If you no longer go for a gap that exists, you are no longer a racing driver." — Ayrton Senna

Three million people lined the streets of São Paulo for his funeral. In the Brazilian parliament, every session opened for a week with a minute's silence.

But from this catastrophe came transformation. The FIA overhauled everything: circuit design, barrier standards, the HANS device for head protection, medical facilities, and an entirely new safety philosophy. In the thirty years since Imola, Formula 1 has become one of the safest motorsport categories in the world. Senna did not die for nothing. But he did die. And Formula 1 would spend the next three decades making sure the sport he gave his life to was worth that price.



C H A P T E R 0 6

06 The Red Empire

Schumacher, Ferrari & Five in a Row · 2000–2004

In the aftermath of Senna's death, Formula 1 entered a period of flux. Damon Hill won a championship. Jacques Villeneuve won one. Mika Hakkinen won two back-to-back for McLaren. But from 2000 onwards, the sport tilted irrevocably on its axis — towards a red car, and a driver who had been quietly preparing to own the next decade.

Michael Schumacher is German, relentlessly competitive, and possessed of an almost pathological will to improve. He first won the championship in 1994 and 1995 with Benetton. He then made the most audacious career decision in the sport's history: he left the leading team of the era to join Ferrari, which had not won a Drivers' title since 1979.

It took four years. Schumacher brought his race engineer Ross Brawn and technical director Rory Byrne with him. He drove development programmes with a dedication that bordered on obsessive. The team was rebuilt, retooled, and pointed in a single direction. In 2000, Schumacher delivers Ferrari their first Drivers' Championship in 21 years. He is so overcome at the finish line in Suzuka that he stops the car, climbs out, and sits on the nose, weeping.

SCHUMACHER · FERRARI DYNASTY · 2000–2004

2000 ✦ Champion

Ferrari's first title
in 21 years

2001 ✦ Champion

Dominant from
the opening race

2002 ✦ Champion

Clinched with 6
races to spare

2003 ✦ Champion

Fierce battle —
wins on final day

Then the real dominance begins. 2001: champion again. 2002: so dominant that he clinches the title with six races to spare — the earliest ever at that point. 2003: another fierce battle, another title. 2004: thirteen wins from eighteen races, the championship wrapped up with five rounds remaining. Five consecutive titles. Nobody has matched it before. Nobody has matched it since.

“

"Every time I see the Ferrari logo, I feel something. It is not just a car. It is a dream." — Michael Schumacher

Schumacher Career Record	Stat
Championships	7 (shared record with Hamilton)
Race victories	91
Pole positions	68 (record at time of retirement)
Best single season	2004 — 13 wins from 18 races
Consecutive titles	5 in a row, 2000–2004 (never matched)

Behind the statistics was a human story: a man from Kerpen, a small German town, who had once kart-raced on second-hand tyres his family could barely afford, who had built himself through sheer will into the most decorated driver the sport had ever seen.

In 2006, after a fierce final campaign against Fernando Alonso, Schumacher retires. Somewhere in the junior formulas, an 18-year-old British driver named Lewis Hamilton is about to begin his Formula One career.



C H A P T E R 0 7

07 The Silver Age

Hamilton, Mercedes & Seven · 2014–2020

When Lewis Hamilton joins Formula One in 2007, the sport has never seen anything quite like him. He is 22 years old, Black in a sport that is almost exclusively white, and blindingly fast from his very first race. He comes within one point of the championship in his debut season. He wins it in 2008, with McLaren, on the final corner of the final lap, in the rain, in Brazil. But the era that will define him does not begin until 2014.

That year, the FIA introduces turbocharged hybrid engines — a V6 combustion unit paired with an electrical energy recovery system. The technology is ferociously complex. One team masters it completely, almost immediately, and that team is Mercedes. With Hamilton and teammate Nico Rosberg at the wheel, Mercedes wins 16 of 19 races in 2014.

HAMILTON · THE RECORD BOOK

Race wins
106

Pole positions
104

Championships
7

Podiums
206

Hamilton takes the title in 2014, his second. In 2015, his third. In 2016, after a bitter internal war with Rosberg that nearly fractures the team, Rosberg wins — and then, astonishingly, retires five days later. In 2017, Hamilton is back. In 2018, again. In 2019, again. In 2020 — racing through a pandemic, in empty grandstands — again. Seven world championships. Tied with Schumacher.

Hamilton battles racism openly in a sport that is slow to acknowledge it. He speaks about the isolation of being the only Black driver in the paddock, about his father working multiple jobs to fund his karting career. He uses his platform for activism in ways that polarise fans and thrill others. By 2020, he represents something larger than Formula 1 itself.

But there is one record that eludes him. Eight world championships. The one that would separate him definitively from Schumacher. In 2021, he chases it — and runs headlong into a 24-year-old from the Netherlands who has no interest in being anyone's footnote.

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"I have always been the underdog. It keeps you hungry." — Lewis Hamilton



C H A P T E R 0 8

08 The New King

Verstappen & the World We're In · 2021–

Abu Dhabi, 12 December 2021. The final race of the season. Lewis Hamilton leads the championship by eight points. He leads the race by ten seconds. He is, to all appearances, on the verge of his eighth world title. Five laps remain.

Nicholas Latifi crashes his Williams into the barrier at Turn 14. The safety car comes out. Red Bull brings Max Verstappen in for fresh, ultra-soft tyres. Hamilton, on 40-lap-old rubber, stays out.

With one lap remaining, race director Michael Masi makes a decision that will divide the sport for years: only the five cars between Verstappen and Hamilton are permitted to un-lap themselves, instead of all lapped cars as the rules normally dictate. The safety car comes in. One lap of racing remains. Verstappen is on new tyres. Hamilton is on old ones.

ABU DHABI 2021 · THE MOST CONTROVERSIAL FINISH IN F1 HISTORY

Standings going in

Hamilton	369.5	pts
Verstappen	369.5	pts
(exactly equal)		

The incident

Safety car Lap 57 of 58 5 of 9 lapped cars cleared (contra normal procedure)

The result

Verstappen	passes
Hamilton	on final lap —
wins race and championship by 1 pt	

In Turn 5, Verstappen goes around the outside of Hamilton. Hamilton defends. Verstappen gets through. He wins the race. He wins the championship. Hamilton sits in his car for a long time after crossing the line. Mercedes files a protest. It is rejected. Masi is found to have acted in good faith but in error. He loses his job. The FIA declares the result valid.

Verstappen is World Champion. It is the most controversial finish in Formula One history. It is also, somehow, perfect: the sport that has always trafficked in drama and injustice, producing a moment that is both.

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"I just want to win races. Everything else is secondary." — Max Verstappen

In 2022, Verstappen wins 15 races and the championship with ease. In 2023, it becomes absurd: 19 wins from 22 races, leading 75% of all laps — a record higher than Jim Clark's legendary 1963 season. In 2024, the rivals close the gap, but Verstappen still claims his fourth title. In 2025, Lando Norris finally breaks through for McLaren to claim the title that had eluded him.

As of 2026, Hamilton has moved to Ferrari — the team of Schumacher, Lauda, and legend — searching for that elusive eighth championship. Verstappen remains the benchmark. The sport is the richest, most-watched, and most competitive it has ever been.

Formula 1 began on a converted airfield in Northamptonshire, with seventy thousand people and a king in the grandstand. It now reaches five hundred million viewers across the globe, fills 24 circuits on six continents, and generates revenues exceeding three billion dollars a year.

But on a Sunday afternoon, when the lights go out and twenty cars accelerate towards the first corner, none of that matters. What matters is the same thing that mattered in 1950: who is fastest, who is bravest, and who — when the wheel is in their hands and the corner is coming at three hundred kilometres an hour — refuses to lift.

The flag drops.

Full throttle.



Key Facts & Stats

A quick-reference guide to the records, milestones, and numbers that define Formula 1.

World Champions (Selected)

Driver	Championships
Giuseppe Farina	1 title — 1950 (first ever champion, Alfa Romeo)
Juan Manuel Fangio	5 titles — 1951, 1954, 1955, 1956, 1957
Jim Clark	2 titles — 1963, 1965
Niki Lauda	3 titles — 1975, 1977, 1984
Alain Prost	4 titles — 1985, 1986, 1989, 1993
Ayrton Senna	3 titles — 1988, 1990, 1991
Michael Schumacher	7 titles — 1994, 1995, 2000–2004
Fernando Alonso	2 titles — 2005, 2006
Lewis Hamilton	7 titles — 2008, 2014–2015, 2017–2020
Max Verstappen	4 titles — 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024
Lando Norris	1 title — 2025 (McLaren)

All-Time Records

Record	Holder / Detail
Most race wins	Lewis Hamilton — 106
Most pole positions	Lewis Hamilton — 104
Most world championships	Hamilton & Schumacher — 7 each
Most wins in one season	Max Verstappen — 19 (2023)
Most dominant team season	McLaren MP4/4 — 15 of 16 wins (1988)
First F1 champion	Giuseppe 'Nino' Farina — 1950
Youngest race winner	Max Verstappen — 18 years, 228 days (2016)
Most consecutive team titles	Mercedes — 7 Constructors' in a row (2014–2020)
Most laps led, single season	Verstappen 2023 — 75% of all laps

Landmark Races

Race / Season	Why It Matters
1950 British GP, Silverstone	First ever F1 World Championship race. Won by Farina.
1957 German GP, Nurburgring	Fangio's greatest drive — overcomes pitstop disaster.
1976 German GP, Nurburgring	Lauda's near-fatal crash. The safety debate is redefined.
1976 Japanese GP, Fuji	Hunt champions as Lauda withdraws in biblical rain.
1988 Japanese GP, Suzuka	Senna's first title. McLaren win 15 of 16 that year.
1989 Japanese GP, Suzuka	Senna and Prost collide. Prost is champion.
1994 San Marino GP, Imola	Ratzenberger and Senna killed. Safety revolution begins.
2008 Brazilian GP, Interlagos	Hamilton wins title on last corner, last lap, in the rain.
2021 Abu Dhabi GP, Yas Marina	Most controversial finish ever. Verstappen champion.
2023 full season	Verstappen: 19/22 wins — most dominant season in history.

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FULL THROTTLE: A Story of Formula 1

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